

TOPIC 4: ENVIRONMENTAL DEGRADATION – BUSH BURNING

1. Meaning of Bush Burning

Bush burning is the practice of setting fire to vegetation (grass, shrubs, trees) on farmland or in the bush. It is commonly done by farmers to clear land for planting, by hunters, or accidentally. Although it may seem quick and cheap, it causes serious environmental damage.

2. Causes of Bush Burning

- Clearing land for farming (traditional method)
- Hunting (to drive animals out)
- Accidental fires from cigarettes, cooking fires or children playing with fire
- Burning of refuse near bushes
- Intentional burning for pasture regeneration by herders

3. Effects of Bush Burning

On Soil:

- Destroys organic matter and soil organisms (earthworms, microbes)
- Reduces soil fertility and structure
- Increases soil erosion because vegetation cover is removed

On Air:

- Releases smoke and harmful gases (carbon dioxide, carbon monoxide) → air pollution
- Contributes to climate change and respiratory problems

On Living Organisms:

- Kills plants, insects, birds, small animals and their habitats
- Reduces biodiversity
- Can spread to destroy houses, farms and forests

4. Alternatives to Bush Burning

- Manual or mechanical clearing of land (cut and remove vegetation)
- Composting of plant remains instead of burning
- Use of herbicides (carefully and under guidance) where appropriate
- Controlled grazing and rotational farming
- Mulching with plant residues to improve soil
- Afforestation and agroforestry practices

5. Importance of Environmental Conservation

Environmental conservation means protecting and carefully managing natural resources (soil, water, air, plants and animals) so that they remain available for present and future generations. Avoiding bush burning is one important way to conserve the environment. Conservation ensures food security, clean air, biodiversity and sustainable development.

6. Summary

Bush burning is the setting of fire to vegetation. It damages soil, pollutes air and destroys living organisms. Better alternatives exist for clearing land. Conserving the environment through good practices is essential for a healthy future.

End of Topic 4 – Bush Burning